

Connecting bridge: On the Chenab Rail Bridge

The rail link will bring Kashmir closer to the rest of India

'Kashmir to Kanniyakumari' is a figurative expression to denote the **geographical expanse** of India, from its northernmost point to its southern tip, and for the first time in history these are connected by rail. With the **inauguration** of the 272-kilometre Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link (USBRL) project which has been 28 years **in the making**, the Kashmir Valley has been connected to the national rail network. The tough, **unsurmountable topography** of the Himalayas **challenged** the engineering capabilities of the Indian Railways, but it has come out **with flying colours**. The engineering **marvel**, the Chenab Rail Bridge, that stands 35 metres higher than the Eiffel Tower, **is** the world's highest railway arch bridge at 359 metres above the riverbed. Spanning 1,315 m, it will **endure** wind speeds of up to 260 km per hour and has been built to **last** 120 years. Nearby, the Anji Khad Bridge, rises **boldly** across the **rugged terrain** as India's first cable-stayed railway bridge. Towering 331 m above the riverbed and **stretching** 725 m across, it is **anchored** by 96 high-tensile cables; 8,200 metric tonnes of structural steel went into its construction. Built at a cost of ₹43,780 crore, the USBRL link **witnessed** drilling of mountains to **set up** 36 tunnels that span 119 kilometres and 943 bridges through **ridges** and mountain passes.

Kashmir's **decades** of geographical **isolation** **have** finally **come to an end**. **The Vande Bharat Express** between Srinagar in the Kashmir region and Katra in the Jammu region, which was also **flagged off** by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, **cuts** the surface journey to three hours between the two points. Later this year, a scheduled direct train **service** between the national capital New Delhi and Srinagar **will** allow **commuters** to touch base in just 13 hours compared to over 24 hours in the past. **The Vande Bharat Express**, a long-distance high-speed service, **is bound to end** the **psychological** barriers, **multiply** the development **dividend** and act as a game changer for the economy of Jammu and Kashmir (J&K). The train service has brought **renewed** hope to the region not long after the Pahalgam terror attack in April 2025 pushed India and Pakistan to a short conflict. India's '**Operation Sindoor**', against terror **infrastructure** across the border, **saw** Pakistan ending the **ceasefire** agreement and targeting civilians, leaving 18 dead and over 1,500 houses damaged. While inaugurating the train service in Katra, Mr. Modi rightly described the rail link as "a symbol of a new, **empowered J&K**". The bridge will **go a long way** to bring the people of Kashmir closer to the rest of India. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

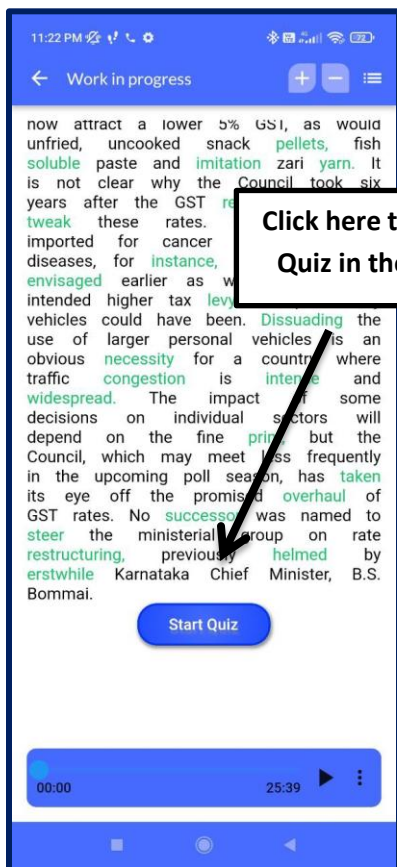
1. **Geographical** (adjective) – spatial, territorial, regional, areal, locational
भौगोलिक
2. **Expanse** (noun) – stretch, spread, area, range, extent विस्तार
3. **Inauguration** (noun) – launch, opening, commencement, initiation, dedication
उद्घाटन
4. **In the making** (phrase) – in progress, underway, under construction, in development, in preparation निर्माणाधीन
5. **Unsurmountable** (adjective) – insurmountable, unconquerable, unscalable, impossible, impassable अजेय / न पार किया जा सकने वाला
6. **Topography** (noun) – terrain, landscape, geography, surface, contour स्थलाकृति
7. **With flying colours** (phrase) – successfully, triumphantly, victoriously, outstandingly, excellently शानदार सफलता के साथ
8. **Marvel** (noun) – wonder, miracle, spectacle, phenomenon, masterpiece चमत्कार
9. **Endure** (verb) – withstand, tolerate, survive, resist, bear सहना / झेलना
10. **Last** (verb) – endure, persist, survive, remain, continue टिकना / लंबे समय तक रहना
11. **Boldly** (adverb) – courageously, daringly, fearlessly, bravely, audaciously साहसपूर्वक
12. **Rugged** (adjective) – rough, uneven, harsh, craggy, jagged उबड़-खाबड़
13. **Terrain** (noun) – a stretch of land, especially with regard to its physical features. भूभाग
14. **Stretch** (verb) – extend, span, reach, spread, elongate फैलना / विस्तृत होना
15. **Anchor** (verb) – secure, fasten, fix, attach, moor स्थिर करना
16. **Witness** (verb) – observe, see, experience, undergo, record साक्षी होना
17. **Set up** (phrasal verb) – establish, construct, create, install, build स्थापित करना
18. **Ridge** (noun) – hilltop, crest, elevation, spine, rise पहाड़ी धार / कगार
19. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years, दशक
20. **Isolation** (noun) – separation, seclusion, remoteness, detachment, exclusion अलगाव
21. **Come to an end** (phrase) – finish, conclude, terminate, cease, stop समाप्त होना
22. **Flag off** (phrasal verb) – launch, initiate, start, inaugurate, dispatch शुभारंभ करना

23. **Commuter** (noun) – traveler, passenger, daily traveler, rider, regular traveler यात्री (विशेषकर रोज़ यात्रा करने वाला)
24. **Bound to end** (phrase) – certain to finish, destined to stop, sure to conclude, inevitably cease निश्चित रूप से समाप्त होना
25. **Psychological** (adjective) – mental, emotional, cognitive, inner, psychic मानसिक
26. **Multiply** (verb) – increase, expand, escalate, grow, amplify बढ़ाना
27. **Dividend** (noun) – benefit, return, profit, advantage, gain लाभांश / लाभ
28. **Renewed** (adjective) – revived, refreshed, restored, reestablished, reenergized नवजीवित / पुनः आरंभ
29. **Infrastructure** (noun) – framework, foundation, base, system, facilities बुनियादी ढांचा
30. **Ceasefire** (noun) – truce, armistice, suspension of hostilities, peace agreement, stoppage युद्धविराम
31. **Empower** (verb) – authorize, enable, strengthen, equip, entitle सशक्त बनाना
32. **Go a long way** (phrase) – greatly help, contribute significantly, be very effective, assist deeply, be useful बहुत सहायक होना / बहुत प्रभाव डालना

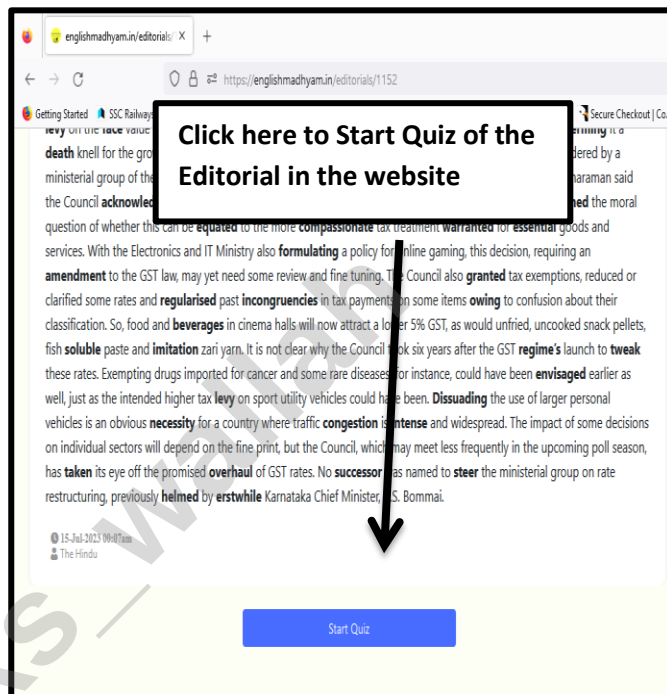
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Historic Rail Link Established:** The Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link (USBRL) has finally connected Kashmir to the rest of India by rail for the first time.
2. **Project Took 28 Years:** The USBRL project, spanning 272 km, was in the making for nearly three decades due to tough terrain and logistical challenges.
3. **Chenab Rail Bridge – An Engineering Marvel:** Standing 359 m above the Chenab riverbed, the bridge is the world's highest railway arch bridge—35 m taller than the Eiffel Tower.
4. **Bridge's Strength and Longevity:** The Chenab Bridge can withstand wind speeds of 260 km/h and is designed to last 120 years.
5. **Anji Khad Bridge – India's First Cable-Stayed Rail Bridge:** The 331 m high and 725 m long Anji Khad Bridge used 96 high-tensile cables and 8,200 metric tonnes of steel.
6. **Massive Infrastructure Effort:** The USBRL involved the construction of 36 tunnels (119 km) and 943 bridges through Himalayan mountains.
7. **Project Cost:** The total cost of the USBRL project is ₹43,780 crore.
8. **Symbol of National Integration:** The rail link symbolizes the unification of Kashmir with the rest of India, geographically and psychologically.
9. **High-Speed Connectivity:** The Vande Bharat Express now connects Srinagar and Katra in just 3 hours, significantly cutting travel time.
10. **Upcoming Direct Delhi-Srinagar Train:** A direct train from New Delhi to Srinagar, set to start later in 2025, will reduce journey time from 24 hours to 13 hours.
11. **Boost to J&K's Economy:** Improved connectivity is expected to unlock economic opportunities and increase development in Jammu & Kashmir.
12. **Psychological Impact:** The rail service is seen as a step toward reducing the sense of alienation and isolation in Kashmir.
13. **Backdrop of Conflict:** The project comes soon after the April 2025 Pahalgam terror attack and subsequent Indo-Pakistan hostilities.
14. **'Operation Sindoor' and Aftermath:** India's military response led to Pakistan ending a ceasefire, causing civilian casualties and damage.
15. **PM Modi's Message:** At the inauguration, PM Modi hailed the rail link as a "symbol of a new, empowered J&K," highlighting its transformative potential.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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